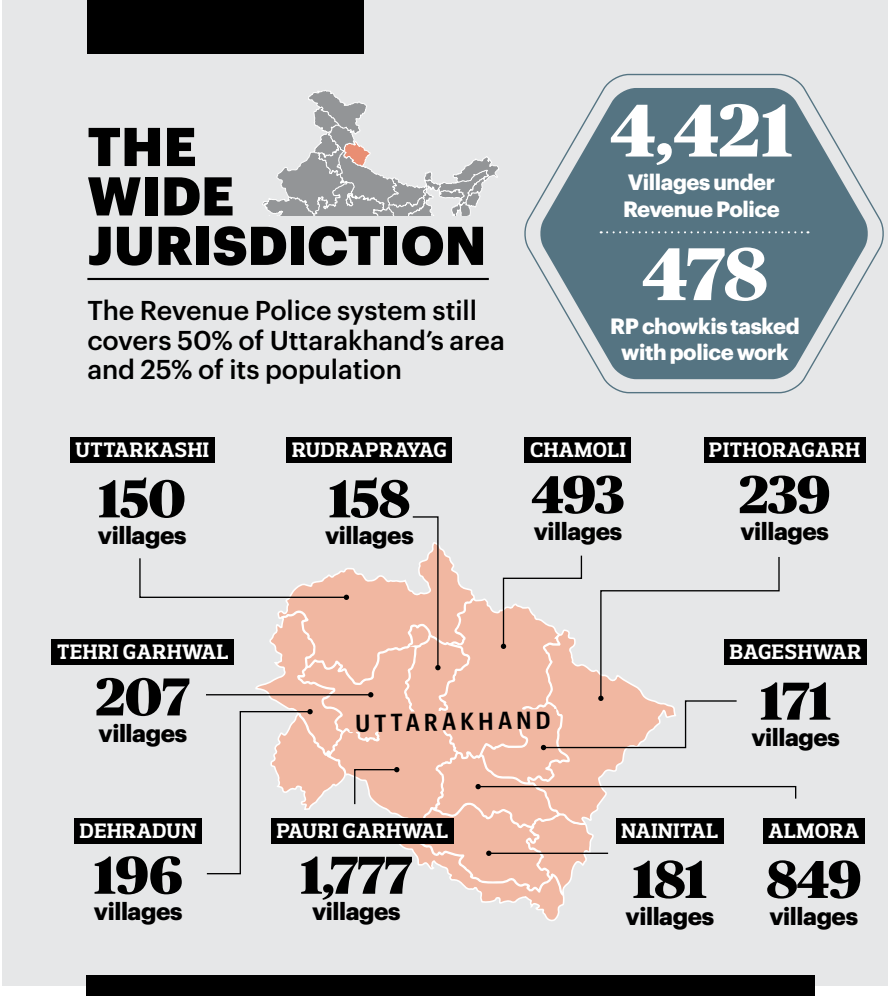


Revenue Police (RP) system, introduced by the British in the early 19th century, still serves nearly half the state's area and about 25 per cent of its population. RP officials can file FIRs, investigate crimes, arrest suspects and submit chargesheets in court, but only up to a point. Cases of serious crime are transferred to the regular police, triggering a slow bureaucratic relay: from patwari to district magistrate (DM) to superintendent of police (SP) to the police station concerned. Evidence is often lost in the lag.

After years of delay and resistance, the system is now under pressure. In May 2024, the Uttarakhand High Court (HC) gave the state one year to implement a 2018 judgment that had ordered the abolition of the RP system. But with 4,421 villages still under the jurisdiction of 478 RP chowkis, a civil contempt petition was filed recently, citing non-compliance. The court has asked the government to file a response.

The state government, meanwhile, claims progress. According to official data, since 2023, 1,357 revenue villages have been brought under regular police with the setting up of six new stations and 20 outposts. Additionally, the jurisdiction of 52 existing police stations and 19 outposts has been expanded to encompass 1,800 more villages. But a lot of work remains. "In the current day and age, we need police coverage in all areas because their work is not just limited to crime control and law and order," admits Abhinav Kumar, a former acting director-general of police (DGP) of Uttarakhand, who is now posted as additional director-general (ADG), prisons. "At present, almost a fourth of the state's population remains uncovered by the regular police. This is an anomaly that must be corrected."

DESPITE SOME PROGRESS, THE UTTARAKHAND GOVT MISSED THE MAY DEADLINE TO PHASE OUT THE REVENUE POLICE SYSTEM

A COLONIAL RELIC

The RP system began after the British annexed Kumaon and eastern Garhwal (present-day Pauri Garhwal) from the Gurkhas in 1816. Finding little crime in the rugged hills, they chose not to deploy regular police outside towns like Almora and Nainital, instead giving police powers to revenue officials. After the 1857 revolt, while modern policing spread elsewhere, the British retained the RP model in hill areas under the Scheduled Districts Act of 1874. Also tried in parts of present-day Himachal Pradesh, Assam and some tribal regions, it was phased out there decades ago. Uttarakhand was carved out of Uttar Pradesh in 2000, and its own Police Act came in 2007—but in many districts, the colonial system stayed in place.

These days, however, crime in the hills is no longer rare or simple. The rise of tourism, road networks connecting remote villages, the proliferation of mobile phones and porous borders have brought in organised crime, drug trafficking and cybercrime. "Tourism brings new challenges," says a retired IPS officer who served in both UP and Uttarakhand. "When outsiders are involved, coordination is nearly impossible for the revenue police. Getting forensic help is also hard."

In RP areas, the patwari—who may be as young as Roshni—is the top investigating officer, regardless of the nature of the crime. There is no supervisory chain of command like in regular police stations, where cases are overseen by sub-inspectors, inspectors and deputy SPs. Training is minimal; one patwari admitted they had barely been briefed on the new Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, which replaced the colonial-era Indian Penal Code (IPC) last year.

This lack of training can have serious repercussions. The 2018 HC judgment stemmed from a 2011 dowry death case in Tehri Garhwal, which exposed delays and inefficiencies in